

compromise required not only on vacation but throughout life. If everybody gets a chance to pick one special thing to do, then they will assume ownership of the trip and enjoy it all the more.

SOUVENIRS

Here's another way to break the budget, to be sure.

12. Avoid souvenir shops altogether

The best way to avoid going overboard with souvenirs (or to disappoint the kids by insisting they can't have anything they see) is to avoid the souvenir shops altogether. Many of the goods in such shops are mass-produced, overpriced, and not authentic.

Instead, try choosing one or two things you want to take home with you that will remind you of your trip and be a special memento. Or, like your tour choices above, get everybody in the family to pick one thing they want as their own personal souvenir from the trip. Everybody can research the destination prior to going to find the trip memento that characterizes the trip best for them, and will be all the more pleased with the end result.

For example, my souvenirs from Australia are a black opal and personally handcrafted didgeridoo. From South Africa, I have a mask and piece of blue tanzanite. From Thailand, a silk shirt and photograph of a monk praying. These are all things I can enjoy in my home, or use practically, and have fond memories of every time I use it.

BUDGET

The best way to avoid sticker shock when you return is to budget the trip to begin with. There are a number of ways you can stick to your guns while on the road.

13. Leave credit cards at home

By bringing traveler's checks and spending only those, you know exactly what you'll have left over when you get home. No nasty surprises. When the checks are running low mid-trip, then you'll figure out where to scrimp if you need to.

14. Set daily meal cost limits

Accommodation, flights, and tours are often fixed prices and you know before you even leave home how much you'll be spending. But meals